Bairam coming for a chat was so daunting, it seems, that it would send Akbar's court scurrying back to Kabul as even the threat of Hemu's fearsome elephants had not.

Akbar put his foot down. He would not leave. But – and with, perhaps, the fear of Maham's exile in mind – he would not meet his ex-regent either. He sent men to block Bairam's way and tell him to stay away: 'for [the emperor] would not see him'.

Bairam did not insist. Instead, he declared he would go to Mecca. Clearly, however, he was seething. He released two political prisoners, including the very first of Akbar's disaffected nobles, Shah Abul Ma'ali. It was a bit like leaving the gas to leak in a house as you leave it. Did Bairam hope Akbar would panic at the thought of 'experienced troublers'[96] on the loose, and call his Khan Baba to set things right?

Akbar did, in fact, send Bairam two messages, but neither revealed any change of heart. The first was a letter[97] in which Akbar offered Bairam cold encouragement for his journey to Mecca, and a fief to sustain him. It may be as a result that Bairam began to march northwards, heading to Punjab, it seems, rather than the ports of Gujarat. Akbar rode out of Delhi with an army to block Bairam's way, sending a messenger ahead. This second message was oral, to be conveyed by Mir Abdul Latif, recently appointed Akbar's tutor.

Abdul Latif was a congenial man. Abul Fazl and Badauni, for example, who could hardly agree on what day of the week it was, both write of him with admiration.[98] If Akbar – or his advisers – intended to soothe Bairam's ruffled feathers, Abdul Latif was the man for the job.

While Akbar was young, said the amiable tutor, he had left governance to Bairam, but now that he had turned his attention to 'affairs of government', it would be best if Bairam went on the Haj. He had often longed to do so, after all, 'in public and in private'; and Akbar would be more than happy to give him 'whatever place and whatever extent of land' in Hindustan to support his journey.[99]

Bairam Khan hesitated. Instead of marching to Lahore, he remained in Mewat, somewhere between Alwar and Delhi. Akbar, too, returned to Delhi; and with the imperial troops so close by, a fresh wave of desertions hit Bairam. In May 1560, as summer set in, the ex-regent gave up. He sent a